



{Q I don't feel very well. What medications are considered safe in pregnancy?

It's normal to get sick from time to time during pregnancy (especially since your immune system is suppressed), but the over-the-counter (OTC) medications you would naturally turn to if you weren't pregnant aren't necessarily safe. Be extra careful and always check with your doctor before taking any remedies.

Many minor ailments, such as common colds and diarrhea, resolve themselves without medication. If you think you do need treatment, seek advice from a doctor—and always let him or her know you are pregnant. Before using an OTC remedy, check with the

pharmacist that it's safe in pregnancy, take it at the lowest dose possible, and limit using it to the shortest amount of time possible. Many natural medicines—and particularly herbal remedies—can be unsafe for your developing baby.

Take care of yourself Even if you don't feel like sleeping, lying down and putting your feet up will give your body a chance to rest. Propping yourself up against a pillow can help ease congestion and an aching back.

For a blocked nose or congestion Inhale steam (with nothing added). You should also drink lots of fluids if you have a cold.

For a sore throat or cough Take lemon, ginger, and honey mixed in hot water or a spoonful of honey straight out of the jar.

It is best to avoid **over-the-counter medications** entirely—especially in the first trimester when your baby is most susceptible to risk.

Prevention is better than cure

You can be more susceptible to infections during pregnancy because your body is suppressing its immune system in order to maintain your pregnancy. You can boost your immunity and protect yourself against infection through good diet, moderate exercise, and sensible hygiene.

» **Wash your hands** before preparing or eating food, and practice safe toileting habits.

» **Drink plenty of water** and diluted juice, too, since fluids will help flush any infection from your system.

» **Boost your intake** of antioxidant foods (such as fruit and vegetables), which can support your immune system.

» **Get plenty of rest** since you're more likely to become sick if you feel tired and depleted.

» **Always talk to a doctor** before taking any natural remedy, even something as seemingly innocuous as an herbal tea.

